Literature Review: Exchange, Society, and the Himalayan Salt Economy

1.1 Introduction

Salt has occupied a distinctive place in human history. Essential for survival yet unevenly distributed across landscapes, it has shaped patterns of mobility, exchange, political authority, and social organisation across diverse societies. Historical research on salt has focused extensively on aspects such as trade, taxation, state monopoly, and imperialism, bringing into relief the economic significance of salt in generating means of subsistence and revenue for the government. These studies have greatly enhanced our knowledge about salt as a strategic good, especially in the contexts of colonial administration and distant trade. Nevertheless, treating salt primarily as an economic good risks overlooking the broader social worlds within which it circulated. Well before the development of capitalism and colonial regulation, however, salt production and transport were practised in the context of reciprocity, customary practice, adaptation to environment, and political rule. Understanding the historical significance of salt therefore requires moving beyond its material value and examining the social institutions that shaped its circulation.

This question takes on particular relevance in the Himalayan region. The Western Himalayas, encompassing one of the world's most biodiverse mountain systems, were bounded by pastoral plateaus, agricultural valleys, monastic centres, and frontier markets., and within this complex cultural landscape existed an extensive network of seasonal exchange. Salt from the saline lakes of Changthang flowed with pashm, wool, grain, tea, livestock, and a variety of other merchandise to connect peoples who inhabited distinctly different ecological zones. Yet these exchanges were rarely merely anonymous commercial transactions between isolated traders; rather, they were shaped by long-standing kinship, reciprocity, custom, and environmental ties that provided stability in a high-altitude borderland. As a result, salt was not just a tradable commodity, but an integral part of a larger ecological and social system.

The Tibetan and Himalayan salt trade has been the subject of an increasing volume of scholarship, and this chapter aims to reflect briefly on these various strands, and to suggest their value and significance. Historians have generally focused on the structure of the salt trade, while the anthropologists pay close attention to the details of everyday economic exchange and exchange systems, especially with regard to floral extraction, pastoral mobility, and the spatial and social dimension of 'netsang' (the trade of salt). This scholarship has shed light on the ancient trans-Himalayan trade. And yet it is equally valuable to consider the ways in which this trade has been altered and transformed in the 19th and 20th centuries, through colonial rule, assimilation, and taxation. The new scholarship has clearly shown that the Himalayan salt economy is not easily defined by contemporary, and even by historical ideas of 'market exchange'.

Theoretical perspectives developed within anthropology, economic history and social theory provide an important framework for interpreting these historical processes. During the twentieth century scholars increasingly challenged the assumption that markets represented the universal basis of economic life. Marcel Mauss argued that early modes of exchange were based on reciprocity, not contract, while Karl Polanyi explained that non-market economies were embedded within other social institutions and were not isolated market systems. Following in this tradition, James C. Scott and E. P. Thompson explored the moral aspects of economic behavior, stressing the significance of custom, subsistence values, and conceptions of justice among common people's reactions to political and economic transformations. More recently, scholars like Prasannan Parthasarathi pointed out that markets were constructed politically during colonial times, arguing that capitalism was a product of state intervention in history, and not a development from prior forms of economic organization. All of these perspectives offer a conceptual framework for viewing exchange as an institution, not only an economic process.

In order to lay down the conceptual basis of the analysis of the Himalayan salt economy, this chapter relies on these theories. Instead of providing a comprehensive analysis of each scholar's work separately, this chapter will try to synthesize the key debates about the themes of exchange, embedded economies, moral economy, and colonial transformation of exchange systems, in order to place these debates in their historical context of the historiography of the Himalayas. It will not seek to force a theory upon historiography but try to find those concepts which will help explain the economy of salt production, exchange, and trade in the Himalayas. In doing so, the chapter situates the Himalayan salt economy within broader debates concerning reciprocity, political authority, ecology, and social formation.

The chapter is organised into three substantive sections. The first focuses on the literature of gift-exchange systems as studied by Marcel Mauss and Karl Polanyi, and their rejection of the market-centered view of economic life. The second reviews debates on moral economy and colonial transformation, drawing upon the contributions of James C. Scott, E. P. Thompson, and Prasannan Parthasarathi to examine how embedded systems of exchange were reshaped under colonial capitalism. The third section will look at the historiography of the Himalayas itself, and will study the historiography and anthropology of salt, its ecological setting, and social formations within it. Having situated the Himalayan salt economy within these broader intellectual debates, the following chapter turns to the historical archives and primary sources that document the circulation of salt across the Western Himalayas and form the empirical basis of this study.

1.2 Exchange Before Markets and the Embedded Economy

The question of how societies organised economic life before the emergence of market capitalism has occupied historians, anthropologists, and political economists for more than a century. Classical economic thought generally assumes that exchange is governed by rational individuals responding to scarcity through market mechanisms. In such a context, this approach

presupposes a belief that markets are the only possible way of organizing economic activities and reflects the logic of capitalist exchanges in societies where institutions have developed under different conditions. Increasingly, however, scholars have questioned this assumption, arguing that pre-market economies cannot be understood through concepts such as price competition, utility maximisation, or contractual exchange alone. Instead, they suggest that production, circulation, and distribution were embedded within wider systems of kinship, religion, political authority, customary obligation, and ecological adaptation. Certainly, among those authors who transformed our understanding of the issue there are Mauss and Polanyi. Although their approaches have come from different contexts and they have faced quite different historical questions, in their views, both denied the universality of market explanations of exchange and put exchange within the bigger institution of social life.

Marcel Mauss' *The Gift* marked a decisive departure from earlier evolutionary theories that interpreted exchange as an increasingly sophisticated progression from barter to markets. Rather than asking how commercial exchange developed, Mauss sought to understand why gifts, which appeared voluntary, generated enduring obligations between individuals and communities. His answer fundamentally altered anthropological understandings of exchange. Gifts, he argued, were never simple transfers of property. They constituted **"total social facts"** in which economic activity remained inseparable from legal obligations, religious beliefs, political authority, moral expectations, and collective identity. Exchange therefore operated simultaneously across multiple spheres of social life, making it impossible to isolate economic transactions from the institutions that produced and regulated them.

Central to Mauss' formulation is the proposition that gift exchange rests upon three mutually reinforcing obligations: the obligation to give, the obligation to receive, and the obligation to reciprocate. These obligations transformed exchange from an act of individual generosity into a mechanism through which social relationships were continually reproduced. Refusing to give represented a failure of social responsibility; refusing to receive rejected the relationship offered by the giver; while accepting without reciprocating resulted in a loss of honour and social standing. Exchange was therefore governed not by contractual enforcement or monetary calculation but by reciprocal obligation and collective recognition. Wealth acquired value through circulation rather than accumulation, and prestige depended upon an individual's or community's capacity to participate in these reciprocal relationships.

Mauss illustrates these principles through the institution of the *Potlatch* among the Indigenous societies of the north-west coast of North America. During these elaborate ceremonial gatherings, chiefs distributed, consumed, and sometimes deliberately destroyed significant quantities of wealth before assembled communities. Judged according to modern economic rationality, such practices appear wasteful and economically irrational. Yet Mauss demonstrates that their significance lay precisely in their capacity to establish political authority, social prestige, and collective legitimacy. Wealth was accumulated in order to be given away, and generosity itself functioned as a source of power. The Potlatch therefore exemplifies a system in which exchange served political and moral purposes rather than commercial ones, reinforcing the broader argument that economic activity remained inseparable from social organisation.

It is quite obvious when we talk about Mauss' concept of hau or mana, the spiritual essence that lived in the object of exchange in Polynesia. For example, the gift was not considered as the mere commodity that can be taken away from its owner, but rather as an item that contained the essence of the giver, making the receiver responsible for his or her actions due to the continuing obligations. Failure to reciprocate therefore represented more than economic indebtedness. It disrupted relationships that were simultaneously social, religious, and political. Exchange thus became a means through which communities sustained cooperation, established hierarchy, regulated alliances, and maintained social equilibrium. In such a way, Mauss showed that the exchange process was rooted in the relations of obligation within which social life was organized.

Although Mauss convincingly established the social foundations of exchange, his analysis remained primarily concerned with the circulation of gifts and the obligations generated between exchange partners. Karl Polanyi extended this insight by asking a broader question: if exchange was socially embedded, how were entire economies organised before the emergence of market society? His contribution shifted attention from individual acts of reciprocity to the institutional organisation of economic life, thereby providing a more comprehensive critique of market universalism.

Polanyi's distinction between **formalist** and **substantivist** economics represents one of the most influential interventions in twentieth-century economic anthropology. Formalist economics defines economic activity as rational choice under conditions of scarcity and therefore assumes that market behaviour provides a universal model for analysing all societies. Polanyi rejected this assumption by arguing that such a definition reflects the historically specific conditions of capitalist economies rather than the organisation of economic life more generally. In its substantive sense, the economy refers simply to the institutional processes through which societies secure their material livelihoods. The economic activity thus always has political, social, religious, cultural, and other aspects.

Like Mauss, Polanyi identified reciprocity as one of the principal mechanisms through which pre-market societies organised exchange. However, he expanded this framework by arguing that reciprocity formed only one component of a broader institutional structure. Alongside reciprocity, redistribution and householding constituted the principal forms through which societies organised production and circulation. Reciprocity involved exchanges among socially affiliated groups under long-lasting obligations; redistribution accumulated goods at politically or religiously centralized locations and then redistributed them throughout society; while the institution of householding was characterized by collective subsistence-based production rather than trade. Markets certainly existed, but they remained subordinate to these wider institutional arrangements instead of regulating society itself.

Taken together, the writings of Mauss and Polanyi seriously challenge the assumption that markets are inherently the natural form of economic organization. For both authors, economic relations have never developed in environments which exist only in terms of the contractual exchanges between individual interests. The key difference between the two thinkers is one of scope, not of kind. Where Mauss focuses on the obligations generated by gift giving, Polanyi

generalizes this idea to the organizational structure of whole economies. Together they reveal that exchange before capitalism was embedded within society rather than governed by autonomous markets.

These perspectives provide an important conceptual foundation for understanding historical exchange in frontier regions such as the Himalayas. A simple market perspective is not enough to analyze the movement of goods over long distances, since these goods were often transported through institutions based on kinship relations, customary obligations, ecological interdependence, and political power. Exchange therefore represented not merely the movement of goods but the reproduction of wider social relationships that enabled communities to survive within challenging environmental and political landscapes. Yet embedded economies were neither static nor immune to historical change. The expansion of colonial states, the emergence of capitalist markets, and the increasing regulation of labour and resources gradually transformed these earlier systems of reciprocity and redistribution. Understanding this transformation requires moving beyond embedded exchange towards questions of moral economy, customary rights, and colonial political economy—issues that form the focus of the following section.

1.3 Moral Economy, Colonial Transformation, and the Making of Markets

Whereas Mauss and Polanyi show that exchange prior to markets was embedded in a larger social structure, both of them pay relatively less attention to the process of transition of these economies embedded in social institutions. The expansion of capitalist markets, the consolidation of state authority, and the restructuring of labour fundamentally altered earlier systems of reciprocity, redistribution, and customary exchange. It is for this reason that historians and political economists now focus on the process by which these pre-market societies saw the rise of market capitalism rather than the way in which pre-market societies operated. Central to this scholarship is the recognition that markets did not simply replace earlier forms of exchange through economic efficiency or technological progress. Rather, they were historically produced through political intervention, institutional restructuring, and changing relations of power. The writings of James C. Scott, E. P. Thompson, and Prasannan Parthasarathi have been quite important in shaping this approach, despite the fact that all of them study the problem from a different historical perspective.

The idea of moral economy formulated by James C. Scott is one of the most important concepts related to the issue of subsistence and exchange. Writing primarily with reference to agrarian Southeast Asia, Scott challenged interpretations that viewed peasant behaviour as motivated principally by profit maximisation. Instead, he argued that subsistence constituted the central organising principle of peasant economic life. Communities operating close to ecological and economic margins sought above all to minimise risk rather than maximise returns. This "safety-first" principle shaped decisions concerning production, labour, and exchange, favouring

stability over commercial opportunity. Economic choices therefore reflected the constant need to preserve subsistence rather than accumulate wealth.

Scott further argues that pre-capitalist societies were sustained by moral expectations that regulated relationships between rulers and subjects. Reciprocal obligations extended beyond local communities to include landlords, village elites, and political authorities, who were expected to protect the subsistence of those under their authority during periods of crisis. Legitimacy therefore depended not simply upon legal sovereignty but upon adherence to widely recognised norms of reciprocity and social responsibility. When these customary obligations were violated—whether through excessive taxation, inflexible revenue demands, or exploitative extraction—the resulting grievances were understood not merely as economic hardships but as breaches of an accepted moral order. Resistance consequently emerged not from abstract ideological commitments but from attempts to defend long-standing norms of subsistence and justice.

Although developed within a different historical setting, Scott's framework provides a valuable lens for interpreting frontier economies where livelihoods depended upon ecological uncertainty and seasonal exchange. Systems of reciprocity, customary obligation, and mutual assistance functioned not simply as cultural traditions but as practical mechanisms through which communities managed environmental risk. Thus, economic exchanges were linked with social security and contributed to the broader idea of Mauss and Polanyi that markets did not form the organizing principles of pre-capitalist societies.

A similar but separate view can be developed on the basis of the work of E. P. Thompson who formulated the notion of moral economy through his research in eighteenth-century England. Like Mauss and Polanyi, Thompson also dismissed purely economic explanations for the collective protests, stressing that such actions had more to do with traditional concepts of justice, rights, and legitimacy than just hunger. In his study of food riots, Thompson revealed that communities tended to preserve the traditional principles of distribution of vital resources, especially those challenged by market relations. Markets, therefore, were experienced not simply as new economic institutions but as challenges to existing social relationships and collective understandings of justice.

Thompson's broader contribution lies in his insistence that historical change cannot be understood solely through quantitative measures of economic growth or material welfare. Distinguishing between a **"standard of life"** and a **"way of life,"** he argues that processes of capitalist transformation frequently undermined customary institutions, communal practices, and forms of local autonomy even where material conditions appeared to improve. This distinction is particularly significant because it directs attention towards forms of dispossession that remain invisible within conventional economic analysis. The erosion of customary authority, communal regulation, and locally embedded knowledge represents a transformation of social life that cannot be captured through indicators such as prices, wages, or output alone.

Scott and Thompson therefore converge upon a common critique of market-centred histories despite working within different geographical and temporal contexts. Both emphasise that

economic systems are sustained by moral expectations, customary institutions, and collective understandings of legitimacy. The transition towards capitalist markets consequently involved not merely the introduction of new forms of exchange but the reorganisation of social relationships that had previously regulated production, distribution, and access to resources. Where Scott highlights the subsistence ethic that underpinned agrarian communities, Thompson draws attention to the customary rights and communal institutions disrupted by expanding market relations. Together, they demonstrate that capitalist transformation was experienced as a reconfiguration of social life rather than simply an economic transition.

These debates have been extended by **Prasannan Parthasarathi**, whose work on labour, industry, and colonial political economy challenges narratives that portray capitalism as the inevitable outcome of European economic superiority. Examining South Asia within a global comparative framework, Parthasarathi argues that markets are neither autonomous nor historically inevitable. Instead, they emerge through political decisions that reshape labour relations, production systems, and institutional structures. Colonial intervention therefore played a decisive role in reorganising existing economies, not by introducing markets into previously isolated societies, but by altering the conditions under which production and exchange were organised.

Parthasarathi's intervention is particularly important because it shifts attention from exchange alone to the broader political economy of colonialism. The creation of new market relationships that favored the interests of imperialism over the pre-existing systems of production was achieved through labor regimes, commerce, law, and the state. The formation of colonial capitalism was neither spontaneous nor impartial. The active participation of the state in the colonial process was essential. Markets, in this formulation, appear less as natural mechanisms of exchange than as political projects embedded within structures of governance and power.

Taken together, the works of Scott, Thompson, and Parthasarathi significantly deepen the insights offered by Mauss and Polanyi. While the latter demonstrate that pre-market exchange remained embedded within wider social institutions, the former explain how these institutions were progressively transformed through colonial intervention and the expansion of capitalist markets. Embedded economies were not simply displaced by more efficient market systems; they were reconfigured through changes in political authority, customary regulation, labour organisation, and state power. This transformation from the notions of reciprocity and redistribution to taxation, contracts, and regulation constitutes one of the key topics in the historiography of political economy.

The above theories help to develop a framework for studying the Himalayan salt economy. The history of this region provides ample evidence that the system of exchanges was formed by traditional obligations, seasonal migrations, ecological cooperation, and local authorities prior to any regulation through licenses by colonial administrations. Understanding this transformation therefore requires not only a theory of embedded exchange but also an appreciation of how the colonial political economy restructured existing social institutions. The following section turns to the Himalayan historiography itself, examining how historians and anthropologists have

interpreted the relationship between salt, ecology, and social formation across the Western Himalayas.

1.4 Salt, Ecology, and Himalayan Social Formation

Having laid down the theoretical underpinnings of exchange through the ideas of embedded economies and moral economies, it is important to contextualize these conversations by considering the Western Himalayas from both a historical and ecological perspective. The existing literature on the salt economy of the Himalayas indicates that the process of exchange in this region cannot be explained purely in terms of commodity circulation and commercial markets. Rather, historians and anthropologists have consistently shown that salt occupied a central position within a wider network of ecological adaptation, pastoral mobility, political authority, and social organisation. The Himalayan salt economy therefore provides an important empirical setting in which the theoretical perspectives discussed in the previous sections acquire historical significance.

Unlike many lowland commercial economies, the Western Himalayas were characterised by pronounced ecological diversity. High-altitude plateaus, cold arid deserts, fertile river valleys, and forested foothills each possessed distinct environmental conditions that supported different forms of production. Whereas the regions of Changthang and Rupshu had vast amounts of saline water and practiced pastoralism around sheep, goat, and yaks, the neighboring valleys produced cereals, vegetables, and other types of agricultural produce. This environmental diversity created a condition of ecological complementarity in which no single region could remain economically self-sufficient. Instead, communities depended upon seasonal exchange to obtain resources unavailable within their own ecological zones. In such a situation, trade did not happen merely because of the possibility of making commercial gains but as a structural necessity to survive in the ecologically fragmented terrain.

In such an environment, salt became a unique element of significance. Its importance derived not only from its physiological necessity but also from its role in sustaining pastoral livelihoods, facilitating exchange, and connecting environmentally distinct regions. Historical studies of the Western Himalayas have repeatedly demonstrated that salt rarely circulated in isolation. Rather, it formed part of broader commodity circuits linking pashm, wool, barley, grain, tea, livestock, and other products exchanged between pastoral communities, agricultural settlements, monasteries, and regional markets. The movement of salt therefore reflected the circulation of an interconnected economic system rather than the trade of a single commodity. As the project's central research framework argues, salt routes functioned as the infrastructural backbone of wider multi-commodity networks that connected the Tibetan Plateau with Ladakh, Kashmir, Baltistan, Himachal, and adjoining Himalayan regions.

Apart from this, anthropological research shows that such exchanges took place through the existence of certain social structures rather than through impersonal market transactions. Among the most important of these social structures was that of netsang, a system of fictive kinship that created exchange partnerships between different families across ecological zones.

Rather than negotiating each transaction independently, trading partners entered into durable relationships characterised by mutual trust, hospitality, and reciprocal obligation. These partnerships reduced uncertainty within environments where long-distance travel was constrained by altitude, climate, and political frontiers. Exchange therefore relied upon relationships that extended well beyond commercial calculation, reinforcing many of the theoretical observations advanced by Mauss and Polanyi regarding reciprocity and embedded exchange. Within the Himalayan context, commodities circulated because social relationships already existed; exchange did not create these relationships as much as it continually reaffirmed them.

The organisation of salt production itself likewise reflected the embedded character of the regional economy. Studies concerning the Rupshu-Tso Kar basin reveal that extraction was a highly controlled and seasonal activity based on customary institutions instead of individual property rights. Salt was collected during specific periods following seasonal evaporation, with labour organised collectively under locally recognised authorities. The duties of extraction, allocation, and transportation were assigned through village institutions, while access to the salt lakes was still based on customary management and was not left open for unrestricted exploitation. Administrative roles such as the *chu dpon*, *goba*, and *kotwal* coordinated the allocation of extraction areas, organised labour, and mediated disputes arising over access to common resources. Such practices clearly show that the administration of salt resources was a part of the local political structure, which included political, ecological, and social functions instead of market-based property rights.

Also, very important is the role of monasteries and regional political institutions in the Himalayan exchange network. Historical scholarship has shown that monasteries frequently operated as centres of redistribution, collecting taxes, receiving tribute, and facilitating the movement of goods across regions. Their influence extended beyond religious practice to encompass economic coordination and local governance. Salt therefore circulated through institutions that simultaneously exercised ritual authority, political legitimacy, and economic influence. Similarly, caravan routes connected not only producers and consumers but also monastic centres, pastoral settlements, and regional polities, creating networks in which mobility, taxation, and political authority intersected. Exchange consequently cannot be separated from the broader institutional landscape within which it occurred.

The environmental conditions of the Western Himalayas further shaped the temporal organisation of exchange. Seasonal migration determined when caravans could travel, when passes remained accessible, and when extraction could occur. Climatic cycles therefore regulated the rhythm of economic activity, linking production directly to ecological processes. Pastoral mobility, caravans, and salt extraction were interrelated elements of a seasonal cycle instead of separate economic activities. Such tight connection of ecology and exchange separates the Himalayan economy from such models of exchange as the one that assumes constant market activity irrespective of the ecological circumstances.

A recurring theme across the Himalayan literature is that salt functioned simultaneously as an economic resource, a political instrument, and a social institution. Its circulation facilitated not

only the movement of commodities but also the reproduction of social relationships, customary rights, and political authority. Thus, research into the area never treats salt as an object of exchange value only. Rather, it is viewed in a broader context of frontier governance, pastoral organization, mobility, environmental adaptation, and interconnection between regions. Such theories can be considered as an embodiment of those theoretical ideas raised by scholars like Mauss, Polanyi, Scott, Thompson, and Parthasarathi and demonstrating that exchange in the Himalayan region was embedded into the social and political order long before colonial interventions aimed to impose certain forms of governance on this social order through taxation, monopoly, licensing, and regulation.

However, despite being valuable for the area of study, the current research suffers from a number of weaknesses. Much of the literature has focused either on ethnographic accounts of pastoral communities or on descriptive histories of caravan trade and regional commerce. While these studies have substantially enriched understanding of Himalayan exchange, the relationships between commodities, institutions, routes, and political actors often remain dispersed across travel narratives, gazetteers, administrative reports, treaties, and ethnographic observations. Thus, it becomes very challenging to look at the Himalayan salt economy as a unified system. This limitation is particularly evident when attempting to reconstruct the wider networks through which salt linked pastoral communities, monasteries, state authorities, frontier markets, and other commodities. The following chapter therefore turns to the historical archive itself, examining the primary sources through which these relationships can be reconstructed and analysed.

1.5 Conclusion

The literature reviewed in this chapter demonstrates that exchange cannot be understood as a purely economic phenomenon governed solely by market forces. Across anthropology, economic history, and political economy, scholars have consistently challenged the assumption that markets constitute the natural or universal basis of economic organisation. Instead, the works of Marcel Mauss, Karl Polanyi, James C. Scott, E. P. Thompson, and Prasannan Parthasarathi collectively illustrate that economic life has historically been embedded within wider systems of reciprocity, customary rights, political authority, ecological constraints, and moral obligations. Although these scholars differ in their historical contexts and analytical emphasis, they converge in rejecting market universalism and instead emphasise the social and political institutions through which exchange was organised. Together, they provide an important conceptual framework for examining societies where economic activity cannot be separated from the broader structures of social life.

These theoretical frameworks are particularly useful for comprehending the history of the Himalayan salt economy. Not only being a mere tradable item, salt had an important function in the context of interrelated systems of pastoral migration, ecological adaption, religious rituals, and local governance. Historical and anthropological research has shown that its distribution was based on the system of reciprocity, caravan arrangements, redistribution by monasteries, customary regulations, and ecological complementarity. Thus, trade in the Western Himalayas

took place in the context of social systems where people engaged into ecological zones with each other in the relations of long-term nature. Salt emerged not simply as an object of commerce but as a medium through which communities negotiated survival, authority, and interdependence within a geographically fragmented frontier.

At the same time, the reviewed literature indicates that these embedded systems of exchange were neither static nor isolated from wider historical processes. Colonial rule brought about transformation of these institutions through means of taxation, monopolies, licensing system, frontier administration, and increasing bureaucratization. Such transformations did not merely alter patterns of trade; they reshaped the political and social relationships through which exchange had previously been organised. Consequently, the Himalayan salt economy must be understood not only in terms of commodity circulation but also as part of a broader history of state formation, frontier governance, and colonial political economy. The shift from a reciprocal economic system to more regulated markets is one of the central topics in both theoretical and regional historiography analyzed in this chapter.

However, despite all the richness of available literature, there are several historiographical problems with it. The most common feature of the studies of the Himalayan salt economy is their ethno-historical character, focusing on specific communities, regions, or institutions.. While these studies have generated detailed accounts of pastoral societies, caravan networks, monastic economies, and colonial administration, the relationships between commodities, routes, political authorities, and social institutions often remain dispersed across gazetteers, travel narratives, administrative reports, treaties, and ethnographic observations. Consequently, it remains difficult to examine the Himalayan salt economy as an integrated system of exchange operating across multiple regions and institutional scales. This fragmentation presents a methodological challenge for reconstructing the wider political economy of salt and understanding how individual actors, commodities, and institutions interacted within broader historical networks.

It is within this historiographical context that the present study is situated. Instead of supplanting historical and anthropological research of this sort, this thesis aims to supplement these works by bringing together different archive-based evidence on the Western Himalayas salt trade. In doing so, it uses the interdisciplinary methodology based on the historical analysis of archive evidence in order to explore the interconnections between commodities, routes, institutions and political agents. The objective is not simply to reconstruct individual episodes of trade but to understand the wider networks through which salt shaped frontier economies and political authority during the colonial period. The use of computational analysis in this thesis is seen not as an alternative to the conventional historical analysis but as a supplementary method allowing for exploration of the intricate network of transactions that are recorded in dispersed archives.

The following chapter therefore moves from theoretical and historiographical discussions to the historical sources themselves. It examines the principal archival materials—including gazetteers, colonial administrative reports, treaties, travel accounts, and Foreign Department records—that document the circulation of salt across the Western Himalayas. The archives serve as the empirical base for building historical networks of connections established via the

salt trade. Having established the conceptual framework through the literature reviewed in this chapter, the thesis now turns to the historical archive in order to examine how these embedded systems of exchange can be analysed within their broader political and economic context.